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Investigation of the Lebanese Grade 1 English Reading Curriculum with Reference to the Common Core State Standards

Alaa M. Hjeij[1]

1- Lebanese University, Department of English Language & Literature, Faculty of Letters and Human Sciences, LEBANON.

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Abstract

This study evaluates the existing Lebanese Grade 1 English reading curriculum by comparing it with the Common Core State Standards (CCSS) and investigating curriculum alignment with 21st-century learning skills. It examines the curriculum's reading objectives and teachers' reported implementation of planned learning experiences. The study also analyzes planned reading learning experiences to determine their alignment with curriculum objectives and their support for 21st -century learning skills. Data were collected through comparative document analysis of curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and learning activities, together with a questionnaire completed by 60 Grade 1 English language teachers. The data were analyzed using the CIPP evaluation model, comparative content analysis, descriptive statistics, and thematic analysis. The findings revealed only partial alignment between the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum and the CCSS. They also showed inconsistencies between curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and teachers' planned learning experiences. Most teachers using the Lebanese curriculum also reported dissatisfaction with the curriculum and relied on supplementary resources to address perceived gaps. The findings suggest that selected features of the CCSS may provide a useful framework for future revision of the Lebanese curriculum. However, further research is recommended to examine the implementation of skills other than reading in Grade 1 and at other educational levels.

Keywords: Lebanese Grade 1 English curriculum; Common Core State Standards (CCSS); curriculum alignment; reading skills; planned learning experiences; 21st -century learning skills.

الملخص

تتناول الدراسة تقييم أهداف القراءة في منهج اللغة الإنكليزية الحالي في لبنان من خلال مقارنته بمعايير الدولة المشتركة الأساسية CCSS لتحديد مدى توافقه مع مهارات التعلم في القرن الحادي والعشرين. كما و تحلل الدراسة أهداف القراءة في المنهج وتجارب التعلم المخطط لها وفقًا لما أفاد بم المعلمون أثناء التطبيق. جُمعت البيانات من خلال تحليل مقارن للوثائق، شمل أهداف المنهج، والمواد التعليمية، وأنشطة التعلم، بالإضافة إلى استبيان شارك فيه 60 معلمًا ومعلمة للغة الإنكليزية في الصف الأول الأساسي. وحُللت البيانات باستخدام نموذج تقييم CIPP، وتحليل المحتوى المقارن، والإحصاءات الوصفية، والتحليل الموضوعي.

أظهرت النتائج مواءمة جزئية فقط بين منهج اللغة الإنكليزية اللبناني للصف الأول الأساسي ومعايير CCSS، كما كشفت عن عدم اتساق بين أهداف المنهج، والمواد التعليمية، وتجارب التعلم المخطط لها من قبل المعلمين. وأفاد معظم المعلمين الذين يستخدمون المنهج اللبناني بعدم رضاهم عنه واعتمادهم على مصادر إضافية لمعالجة الثغرات الموجودة. وتشير النتائج إلى أن بعض مكونات CCSS قد توفر إطارًا مفيدًا لتطوير المنهج اللبناني مستقبلًا. ويوصى بإجراء مزيد من الدراسات حول تطبيق مهارات أخرى غير القراءة في الصف الأول الأساسي و كذلك في مراحل تعليمية أخرى.

الكلمات المفتاحية : *منهج اللغة الإنجليزية للصف الأول الأساسي في لبنان؛ معايير الدولة الأساسية المشتركة(CCSS) ؛ توافق المنهج؛ مهارات القراءة؛ تجارب التعلم المخطط لها؛ مهارات التعلم في القرن الحادي والعشرين.*

Introduction

Early reading instruction provides the foundation for long-term academic success. Effective literacy development requires the gradual acquisition of essential reading skills, including vocabulary, comprehension, fluency, and appropriate reading strategies. In the Lebanese curriculum, reading instruction emphasizes skills such as demonstrating literal understanding, finding meanings from context clues, and utilizing integrated reading experiences to support learners' comprehension development (CERD, 1997; Dbaibo, 2016). Meaningful reading experiences also encourage learners to apply skills in authentic contexts and develop higher-order thinking abilities.

Curriculum alignment is central to effective curriculum design because it connects learning objectives, instruction, and assessment. Wiggins and McTighe (2021) proposed Understanding by Design (Backward Design), which emphasizes beginning curriculum planning with desired learning outcomes and then designing appropriate assessments and learning experiences. Similarly, Dbaibo (2016) highlighted the importance of aligning the written curriculum with classroom practices through planned learning experiences. These perspectives provide a foundation for examining whether curriculum objectives are effectively reflected in instructional practices.

In Lebanon, the national English language curriculum developed by the Centre for Educational Research and Development (CERD) in 1997 remains largely unchanged despite educational reforms and growing demands for 21st -century competencies (Aljaafil & Beyhan, 2021; Yarak, 2021). Although the curriculum identifies general English language objectives, limited research has examined the alignment of Grade 1 reading objectives with internationally recognized standards. The Common Core State Standards (CCSS) provide a standards-based framework that emphasizes progressive literacy development, critical thinking, comprehension, and authentic learning experiences. The CCSS has been implemented widely in the United States and adopted in parts of the Middle East through Alpha Publishing (Jasperse et al., 2018a).

In language education, 21st -century skills include competencies such as critical thinking, communication, and digital literacy, which enable learners to apply knowledge in authentic contexts. In early literacy instruction, these competencies can be fostered through authentic reading experiences, text-based discussions, problem-solving activities, and technology-supported learning (Zwiers et al., 2014).

Three complementary perspectives guide this study. The first one is Understanding by Design (Backward Design). Wiggins & McTighe (2021) support the examination of alignment among learning objectives, assessment, and instructional activities. Second, Dbaibo's (2016) perspective on curriculum alignment supports the analysis of connections between the written curriculum and planned learning

experiences. Third, Stufflebeam's CIPP Evaluation Model (Context, Input, Process, Product) provides a framework for evaluating curriculum design and implementation (Stufflebeam, 2003).

Despite the importance of curriculum alignment and early literacy development, limited research has examined how the Lebanese Grade 1 English curriculum aligns with international literacy standards. In particular, little is known about the extent to which the curriculum objectives and teachers' planned reading experiences correspond with the CCSS and 21st -century literacy expectations. This study addresses this gap by examining the alignment between the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum and the CCSS, focusing on reading-skill objectives and teachers' planned learning experiences.

The study addresses the following research questions:

1. How do the reading skill objectives of the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum align with the Common Core State Standards (CCSS)?

2. How do teachers' planned learning experiences align with the reading skill objectives of the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum, the Common Core State Standards (CCSS), and 21st -century learning skills?

Methodology

Research Design

This study adopts a mixed-methods approach combining qualitative document analysis with quantitative and qualitative questionnaire data. Using multiple data sources enabled data triangulation and provided a more comprehensive understanding of curriculum alignment, teachers' perceptions, and their planned learning experiences.

Participants and Data Sources

Two sources of data were used: curriculum documents and teacher questionnaire responses. The document analysis included the Lebanese CERD Grade 1 English language curriculum and CCSS-aligned Grade 1 English reading materials published by Alpha Publishing.

The questionnaire was completed by 60 Grade 1 English teachers from Lebanese schools. Thirty participating teachers use the Lebanese national curriculum, whereas thirty use CCSS-aligned materials. Participants represented both public and private schools and provided demographic information on their educational background, teaching experience, and curriculum use.

The document analysis examined reading objectives, instructional materials, and learning activities in both curricula. It focused on the alignment of reading skills, curriculum objectives, and planned learning experiences.

The questionnaire consisted of closed-ended six-point Likert-scale items and open-ended questions. The Likert-scale sections examined teachers' perceptions of the curriculum, reading instruction, and areas requiring curriculum improvement. The open-ended questions explored teachers' planned learning experiences and classroom practices.

Validity and Reliability

The questionnaire was reviewed by an expert in curriculum and English language education to establish content validity. Internal consistency reliability was assessed using Cronbach's alpha (Cronbach, 1951). Cronbach's alpha coefficients ranged from .859 to .950 across all questionnaire sections, indicating good to excellent internal consistency (Taber, 2018).

Data Analysis

Curriculum documents were analyzed using comparative content analysis. The CIPP model (Stufflebeam, 2003) guided the evaluation of curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences. Reading objectives and learning activities were compared to determine their alignment across the targeted reading skills. The skills examined included reading comprehension, fluency, word recognition, phonological awareness, context clues, story elements, print concepts, and authentic learning experiences.

Questionnaire responses were analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistics. Following Salkind (2012), descriptive statistics included frequencies, percentages, means, and standard deviations. Independent-samples t-tests were conducted to compare teachers using the Lebanese curriculum with those using CCSS-aligned materials. Statistical significance was established at $p < .05$, and Cohen's d was calculated to estimate the magnitude of group differences.

Qualitative questionnaire responses were analyzed thematically to identify recurring patterns related to curriculum strengths, challenges, and teachers' planned learning experiences.

Ethical Considerations

Participation in the study was voluntary, and participants were informed about the purpose of the study. Providing names was optional, and participants' identities were kept confidential throughout the research process. Questionnaire responses were used solely for research purposes.

Findings

The findings were presented according to the two research questions and were based on two sources of data: document analysis comparing the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum with the CCSS, and a teacher questionnaire exploring educators' perceptions, practices, and challenges. Together, these data identified areas of alignment, misalignment, and factors influencing curriculum implementation.

Document Analysis

Comparison of the Reading Objectives in Teaching the English Language

The comparison identified similarities and differences across the eight CCSS Grade 1 reading criteria used to organize the CCSS Grade 1 reading standards: Key Ideas and Details, Craft and Structure, Integration of Knowledge and Ideas, Range of Reading and Text Complexity, Print Concepts, Phonological Awareness, Phonics and Word Recognition, and Fluency. The corresponding objectives are summarized in Appendices A and B.

First Criterion: Key Ideas and Details

Under this criterion, the CCSS includes six reading objectives that address comprehension and story structure. These objectives require students to identify characters, settings, major events, key details, the main topic, and the central message in literary and informational texts. The objectives are supported by multiple learning activities throughout the *Alpha Reading materials* (Jasperse et al., 2018b).

In comparison, the Lebanese curriculum addresses only some of these skills. Its objectives focus primarily on identifying characters, suggesting story titles, and recognizing key facts or events in a text. Related exercises are sparse and mainly appear in the workbook or teacher's guide. Unlike the CCSS, the Lebanese curriculum does not explicitly include objectives related to *identifying the main topic of*

informational texts, determining the central message, or systematically analyzing supporting details. Therefore, the Lebanese curriculum demonstrates a narrower coverage of comprehension skills under this criterion.

Second Criterion: Craft and Structure

The Craft and Structure criterion is represented in the CCSS through six objectives and in the Lebanese curriculum through three. In the CCSS, objectives emphasize identifying sensory words, determining word meanings using context, distinguishing between fiction and nonfiction, recognizing narrators, and using text features (e.g., headings or illustrations) to locate key information. These are consistently reinforced through structured textbook and workbook exercises.

The Lebanese curriculum includes related but fewer objectives: *using contextual clues to get meaning, answering simple comprehension questions,* and *interpreting factual information*. The workbook devotes extensive space to context-clue exercises, offering numerous vocabulary and context-based comprehension tasks (Eid et al., 1998c).

Moreover, while the CCSS includes objectives on text structure and point of view, such skills are not formally listed in the Lebanese objectives. Many literal-question tasks in the CERD workbook are not connected to the textbook topics, and the curriculum lacks an explicit objective for this skill.

Third Criterion: Integration of Knowledge and Ideas

This criterion encourages students to synthesize textual and visual information. The CCSS includes five objectives addressing the use of illustrations to describe characters or events, comparing and contrasting stories, identifying an author's supporting reasons, and recognizing similarities and differences across texts. These objectives are well integrated into reading and workbook tasks.

The Lebanese curriculum includes two related objectives: *relating text to visual illustrations* and *equating words with corresponding illustrations*. Exercises matching words and pictures are limited in scope and depth.

Both curricula connect textual and visual comprehension, yet the CCSS develops higher-order analytical skills, while the Lebanese objectives remain focused on surface-level associations.

Fourth Criterion: Range of Reading and Level of Text Complexity

The CCSS expects students, with prompting and support, to read literary and informational texts of appropriate Grade 1 complexity. A range of lessons over the school year addresses these objectives (Jasperse et al., 2018c, p. xx).

The Lebanese curriculum addresses this broadly through the objective *develop reading strategies*, which is not explicitly tied to text complexity. Thus, while both promote independent reading, CCSS objectives are measurable and progressive, whereas Lebanese objectives remain general.

Fifth Criterion: Print Concepts

In the CCSS, print concepts include understanding how print is organized and recognizing sentence features such as capitalization and punctuation. Exercises reinforce sentence boundaries and punctuation use.

The Lebanese curriculum contains a comparable but narrower objective: *recognize sentence boundaries*, with related matching activities in the workbook. Hence, both curricula address foundational print awareness, but the CCSS covers a wider range of print features.

Sixth Criterion: Phonological Awareness

The CCSS explicitly defines phonological awareness through four objectives: distinguishing vowel sounds, blending and segmenting phonemes, and identifying sound positions. These are reinforced through multiple phonics exercises.

In contrast, the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum does not list explicit phonological awareness objectives, although a few rhyming activities appear incidentally in the workbook. Consequently, phonological awareness is a clear strength of the CCSS but largely absent in the Lebanese framework.

Seventh Criterion: Phonics and Word Recognition

The CCSS outlines a comprehensive set of objectives under *phonics and word recognition*, including decoding, syllable recognition, spelling-sound correspondence, and irregular word reading. Exercises systematically build decoding and word recognition skills.

The Lebanese curriculum lists two objectives: *using phonological and morphological clues to get meaning* and *demonstrating awareness of written discourse structure.* Supporting exercises are limited in number and scope.

Eighth Criterion: Fluency

The CCSS defines fluency through three objectives: *reading grade-level text with understanding, reading aloud with accuracy and expression, and self-correcting through context*. These are practiced daily across units.

The Lebanese curriculum includes a single related objective: *group words into sets of related lexical items, with few exercises.* Therefore, fluency is systematically cultivated in the CCSS, whereas it receives minimal attention in the Lebanese curriculum.

Key Findings from the Document Analysis

The document analysis compares reading objectives across textbooks, workbooks, and teacher guides in both curricula. The CCSS curriculum shows consistent and balanced coverage of the eight reading criteria, with each unit structured around clear objectives. In contrast, the Lebanese curriculum issued by CERD displays an uneven distribution of reading objectives. While several CCSS reading skill areas are represented in the Lebanese curriculum, their coverage is inconsistent. Context clues receive substantial emphasis, whereas integrated reading skills, print concepts, phonological awareness, and the systematic progression of word recognition receive comparatively less attention.

A strong emphasis on context clues is evident in the Lebanese curriculum, with more than 18 workbook pages devoted to this skill, whereas other reading skills appear in only one to six pages. Only two workbook questions address story elements, and although i*dentifying characters* is listed as a curriculum objective, it is not represented in workbook activities. Literal comprehension questions also appear frequently despite the absence of corresponding written objectives, indicating inconsistencies between curriculum objectives and workbook activities.

Regarding integrated reading skills, the Lebanese curriculum includes the objective of connecting texts to visual illustrations, partially corresponding to the CCSS objective of using "illustrations and details in a story to describe its characters, setting, or events" (Jasperse et al., 2018c). However, the CCSS materials incorporate a broader range of activities, including drawing characters, comparing story elements through Venn diagrams, and discussing text evidence. In contrast, the Lebanese curriculum includes fewer activities promoting multiple forms of text engagement and lacks explicit objectives promoting real-life text connections. Many workbook questions remain literal and isolated from the reading passage (e.g., *"Who is fat?" and "Where do you play?*") (Eid et al., 1998c, p. 69).

For print concepts, the CCSS includes rule-based activities such as correcting capitalization and punctuation, whereas the Lebanese curriculum relies primarily on sentence-matching exercises. Phonological awareness is absent as an explicit curriculum objective and appears only occasionally in workbook activities or teacher guide suggestions. Likewise, the CCSS presents explicit, sequential objectives for fluency and word recognition, whereas the Lebanese curriculum addresses these skills more broadly and with less systematic organization.

Overall, the document analysis shows that the CCSS provides more comprehensive and systematically organized coverage of early reading skills than the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum.

Teachers' Questionnaire Results

The questionnaire (Appendix C) consists of five sections (A–E). It was developed following Salkind (2012), with Sections B–D informed by Aljaafil and Beyhan (2021) and Dbaibo (2016). Analysis of Section E drew on planned learning experiences from the Alpha Teacher's Guide, aligned with the CCSS and 21st-century skills (Jasperse et al., 2018c).

Section A – Demographics

A total of 60 Grade 1 English language teachers participated in the study, including 30 using the CCSS curriculum and 30 using the Lebanese curriculum (Figure 1).

Among participants, 56 are females, and 4 are males. Most are aged 31–40 years, hold a bachelor's degree, and have 1–5 years of teaching experience. Fifty-one are Grade 1 English language teachers, nine are department coordinators, and most of them work in private schools (50/60).

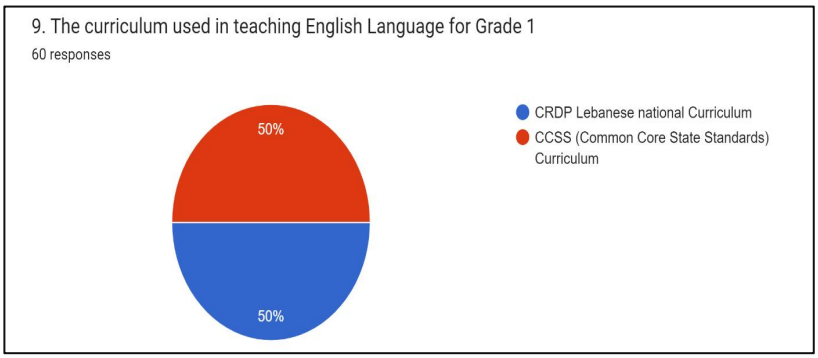


Figure 1: Distribution of the Questionnaire across Two Groups of Teachers Regarding the Curriculum Used

Sections B–D: Teachers' perceptions of the curriculum, reading instruction, and curriculum improvement.

Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics and independent-samples t-test results comparing teachers using the Lebanese curriculum and CCSS-aligned materials.

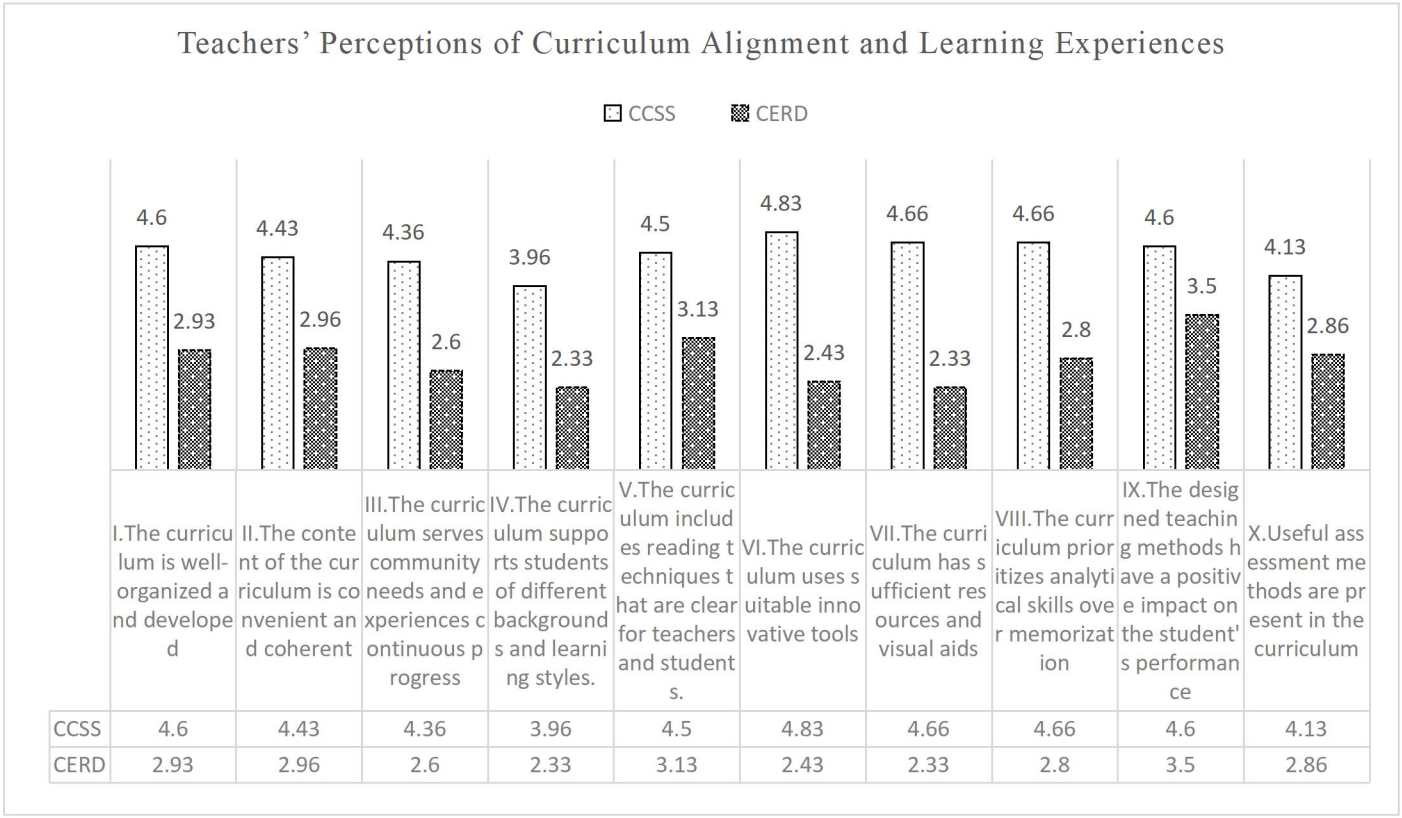
Table 1. Comparison of Questionnaire Scores Between Lebanese Curriculum and CCSS Teachers

Variable	Lebanese Curriculum (n = 30) M (SD)	CCSS (n = 30) M (SD)	*t*(58)	*p*	Cohen's *d*
Section B: Curriculum Perspectives	2.79 (1.23)	4.48 (0.79)	−6.37	< .001	1.64
Section C: Reading Instruction	3.23 (1.04)	4.36 (0.79)	−4.71	< .001	1.21
Section D: Curriculum Improvement	5.29 (1.10)	4.15 (0.98)	4.25	< .001	1.10

Note. *M* = mean; *SD* = standard deviation; *t* = independent-samples *t*-test statistic; *p* = statistical significance level; Cohen's *d* = standardized effect size.

Section B – Curriculum Perspectives

Section B addresses teachers' perspectives regarding CERD's Lebanese National Curriculum and the CCSS. Figure 2 presents the mean responses of the 60 teachers to the 10 statements in Section B, with CCSS teachers represented by the first bar of each item and CERD teachers by the second. Figure 3 outlines the interval scale of the 6-point Likert measure used.



	I.The curriculum is well-organized and developed	II.The content of the curriculum is convenient and coherent	III.The curriculum serves community needs and experiences continuous progress	IV.The curriculum supports students of different backgrounds and learning styles.	V.The curriculum includes reading techniques that are clear for teachers and students.	VI.The curriculum uses suitable innovative tools	VII.The curriculum has sufficient resources and visual aids	VIII.The curriculum prioritizes analytical skills over memorization	IX.The designed teaching methods have a positive impact on the student's performance	X.Useful assessment methods are present in the curriculum
CCSS	4.6	4.43	4.36	3.96	4.5	4.83	4.66	4.66	4.6	4.13
CERD	2.93	2.96	2.6	2.33	3.13	2.43	2.33	2.8	3.5	2.86

Figure 2: Mean Scores of Teachers' Perceptions regarding Curriculum Objectives and Learning Experiences in the CERD and CCSS Curricula

Likert Scale	Interval
1	1.00-1.82
2	1.83-2.65
3	2.66-3.48
4	3.49-4.31
5	4.32-5.14
6	5.15-6.00

Figure 3: Six-point Likert Scale (Pimentel, 2019, p. 188)

Note: 1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Slightly disagree, 4 = Slightly agree, 5 = Agree, 6 = Strongly agree.

On the whole, CCSS teachers agree with most statements, yielding an average of 4.48. They generally consider the curriculum well-organized, coherent, responsive to community needs, supported by clear reading techniques, and equipped with sufficient resources and visual aids. They also agree that it promotes analytical thinking, incorporates effective instructional tools, and has a positive influence on student performance. Mean scores for these items range from 4.36 to 4.83 ("Agree"). Slight agreement is reported regarding support for diverse learners and the usefulness of assessment methods (means 3.96–4.13).

CERD teachers, however, show slight disagreement overall, with an average of 2.79. They tend to view the curriculum as insufficiently organized, lacking coherence, and limited in providing clear reading techniques, analytical skills development, and useful assessment tools (means 2.8–3.13). Only the statement concerning the positive impact of teaching methods received a slightly higher evaluation (M = 3.5, "Slightly agree"). They also disagree that the curriculum serves community needs, supports diverse learners, uses innovative tools, or offers adequate resources (means 2.33–2.6).

To determine whether these differences are statistically significant, an independent-samples t-test was conducted comparing the composite Section B scores of the two groups. The results indicate a statistically significant difference, with CCSS teachers reporting significantly more positive perceptions (M = 4.48, SD = 0.79) than Lebanese curriculum teachers (M = 2.79, SD = 1.23), $t(58) = -6.37$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.64$ (Table 1). The large effect size indicates a substantial difference in teachers' perceptions of the two curricula.

Overall, the findings indicate that CCSS teachers hold significantly more positive perceptions of their curriculum than CERD teachers across most aspects of curriculum organization and instructional support.

Section C – Reading Objectives and Materials

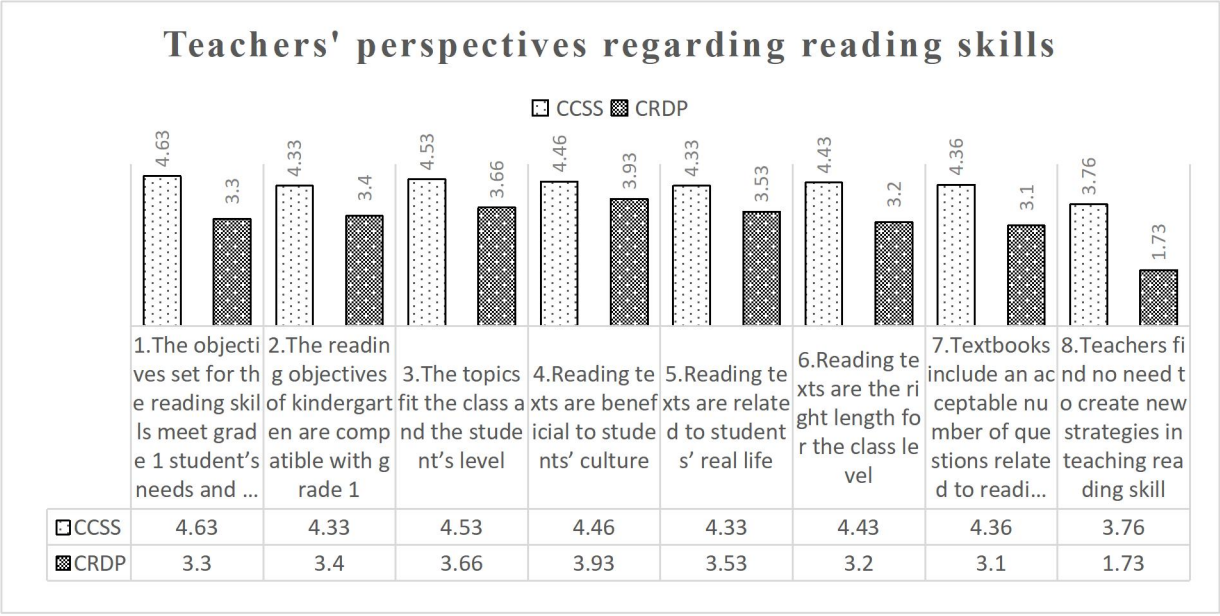


Figure 4: Mean Score of Each Item in Section C concerning Teachers' Perspectives regarding Reading Skills

Figure 4 summarizes teachers' mean responses to the eight statements in Section C. Collectively, CCSS teachers agree that the objectives are appropriate and aligned with kindergarten outcomes, that

the topics suit students' levels, and that the texts are culturally relevant, connect to real life, and are of suitable length. Their mean scores range between 4.33 and 4.63 ("Agree"), indicating general satisfaction with the curriculum's reading objectives and materials. They only slightly agree (M = 3.76) with the statement that no new strategies are needed, suggesting a willingness to consider methodological improvement.

In contrast, CERD teachers generally slightly disagree that reading objectives meet student needs, that kindergarten objectives align with Grade 1, reading texts are of the appropriate length, or that textbooks include an acceptable number of questions related to reading skills (means between 3.1 and 3.4). They slightly agree that topics are level-appropriate and that texts are culturally and personally relevant (means 3.53–3.93). Most strongly disagree (M = 1.77) with the idea that no new reading strategies are needed, highlighting a perceived need for pedagogical development.

In total, CERD teachers report a mean score of 3.32 ("Slightly disagree"), whereas CCSS teachers report 4.44 ("Agree"), revealing stronger approval of the CCSS curriculum's reading components.

An independent-samples t-test confirms that this difference is statistically significant. Teachers using the CCSS report significantly higher ratings for reading objectives and instructional materials (M = 4.36, SD = 0.79) than teachers using the Lebanese curriculum (M = 3.23, SD = 1.04), $t(58) = -4.71$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.21$ (Table 1).

Use of Materials for Lesson Planning

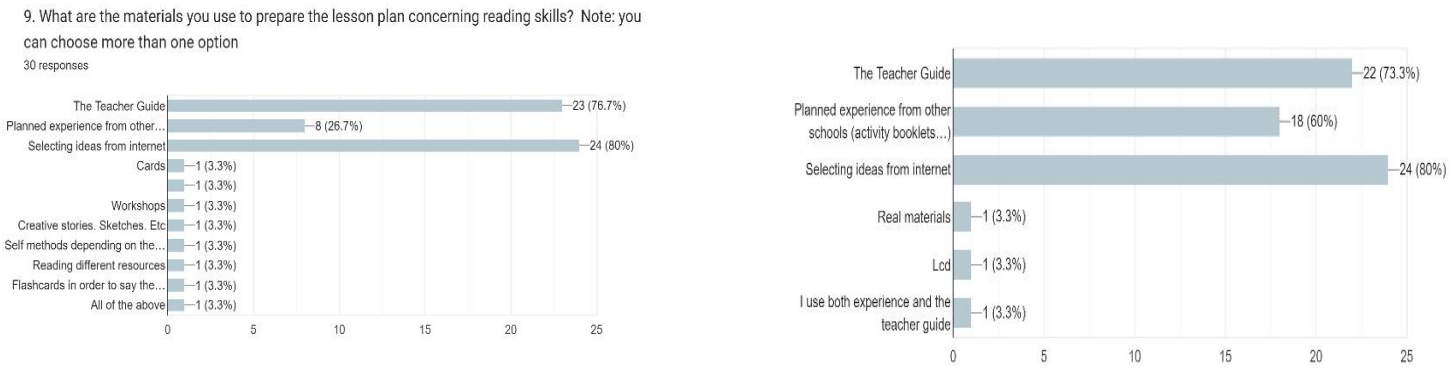


Figure 5: The Materials Teachers Use to Prepare the Lesson Plan concerning Reading Skills: (CCSS is to the left, and CERD is to the right. *Google form result*)

Figure 5 presents responses to Question 9: "What materials do you use to prepare lesson plans for reading skills?"

Teachers from both curricula mainly rely on their teacher's guide and internet resources (73–80%) to plan reading lessons. However, 60% of CERD teachers also use materials from other schools, compared to 26.7% of CCSS teachers. Some teachers further incorporate cards, workshops, LCDs, creative stories, sketches, and self-developed methods based on student needs.

In summary, while both groups primarily depend on teacher guides, CERD teachers demonstrate greater reliance on external and self-created resources, likely to compensate for gaps in the prescribed curriculum.

Section D – Suggestions for Curriculum Development

Figure 6 presents the mean responses of the 60 teachers to the five statements in Section D. Overall, CCSS teachers slightly agree with the statements (M = 4.15), yet CERD teachers demonstrate a higher

level of agreement (M = 5.29), suggesting a stronger perceived need for curriculum reform among CERD teachers.

Across all items, CERD teachers consistently report stronger agreement on the need to:

- Add more reading objectives,
- Integrate technology-based activities,
- Align content with students' real lives,
- Include values and moral education, and
- Increase comprehension-focused activities.

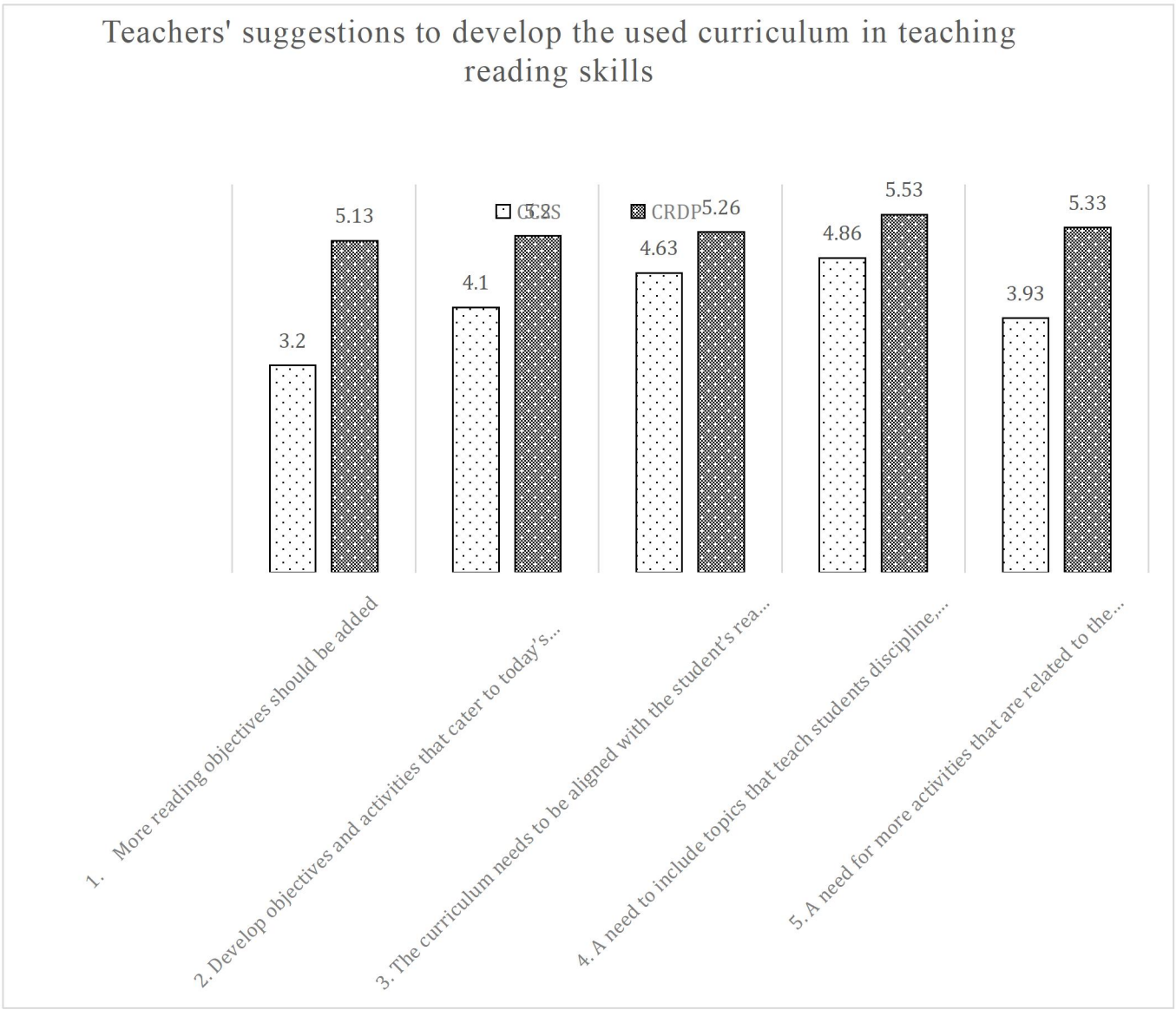


Figure 6: Mean Score of Each Item of Section D concerning Teachers' Suggestions to Develop the Used Curriculum in Teaching Reading Skills

CCSS teachers' responses are more varied, showing mild agreement or disagreement depending on the statement.

Additional CCSS suggestions include focusing on accent improvement, differentiating texts by proficiency levels, and integrating translation and conversation activities. One teacher emphasizes simplifying grammar objectives and prioritizing storytelling and analysis to better support diverse learners. These views align with Zwiers et al. (2014), who note that some students struggle to meet CCSS expectations due to limited academic language proficiency.

CERD teachers express concerns about weak skill integration, overly simple reading texts, and poorly organized projects. They also note the lack of objectives targeting students with learning difficulties.

An independent-samples t-test show that Lebanese curriculum teachers express a significantly greater need for curriculum improvement ($M = 5.29$, $SD = 1.10$) than CCSS teachers ($M = 4.15$, $SD = 0.98$), $t(58) = 4.25$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.10$ (Table 1).

Overall, both groups recognize the need for curriculum enhancement, with CERD teachers highlighting more urgent issues related to content quality and alignment with learners' needs.

Results of Section E: Analysis of Teacher's pre-planned learning experience alignment with the written curriculum and the 21st -century reading skills

Section E compares planned learning experiences for reading skills in the Lebanese Grade 1 curriculum and the CCSS-based *Alpha Teacher's Guide*. The comparison informs Section E of the questionnaire, which asks teachers whether they implement experiences as prescribed or supplement them with additional materials.

The section examines whether CERD teachers rely primarily on the official teacher's guide and whether teachers using the CCSS follow or adapt the planned learning experiences by using fewer, additional, or different instructional strategies. Responses address the alignment of pre-planned experiences with the written curriculum and 21st -century reading skills.

Comparison of Planned Learning Experiences

This subsection compares the pre-planned learning experiences as described in the teacher guides of two curricula: the Common Core State Standards (CCSS) and the Lebanese curriculum published by the Center for Educational Research and Development (CERD). The analysis highlights how these experiences are used to design and introduce reading skills in the classroom.

The pre-planned experiences in the Lebanese and CCSS curricula guide classroom reading instruction. These experiences are intended to support teachers in introducing and developing reading skills.

The Lebanese curriculum introduces five main reading skills, as outlined by Eid et al. (1998b):

1. Comprehension reading skills – Taught through pre-reading, during-reading (silent, choral, or individual reading), and post-reading activities (role-play, retelling, interpretation).
2. Identifying story elements: Story maps are used to highlight characters, plot, setting, and resolution.
3. Context clues: Large flashcards and three levels of vocabulary: taught words, phrases in books, and oral exposure (the traditional memorization of words).
4. Reading fluency: Repetition of dialogues and poems, and monitoring pronunciation errors.
5. Using technology: Teachers are encouraged to explore internet applications aligned with reading objectives.

By contrast, the CCSS curriculum, as outlined by Jasperse et al. (2018c), presents 9 reading skills.

1. Reading Fluency
   - Build background through discussion.
   - Preview the text using pictures.
   - Model clear, fluent reading.
   - Conduct a close reading through rereading and questioning.

2. Comprehension Skills
   - Have students read the selection before answering questions.
   - Let them write questions, then discuss and address them.
   - Read questions aloud and encourage students to refer back to the text.
   - Allow independent or paired work on comprehension tasks.
3. Story Elements
   - Encourage imagination through discussion.
   - Use pictures and text to focus on characters, actions, settings, feelings, and senses.
   - Record and compare students' responses.
4. Integrated Skills Through Authentic Learning
   - Connect two selections using drawings or charts (e.g., Venn diagrams).
   - Imagine new stories with different characters/actions.
   - Compare imagined story elements to the original.
   - Integrate reading with other subjects and link to personal experience through role play.
5. Context Clues
   - Use dialogue to reinforce vocabulary.
   - Have students illustrate vocabulary words.
   - Use pictures/flashcards to derive meanings.
   - Highlight details with Wh-questions.
6. Print Concepts
   - Provide slips with pronouns and punctuation.
   - Write unpunctuated sentences on the board and have students correct them.
7. Phonological Awareness
   - Work in groups to find rhyming and similar words.
   - Practice counting syllables.
   - Identify phonetic features in magazines/newspapers.
   - Use word cards for correct pronunciation.
8. Word Recognition
   - Use single-word slips for sentence creation.
   - Build word trains and combine sentences with conjunctions.
   - Sort word cards.
   - Discuss new vocabulary and present words/sentences to the class.
9. Technology Use
   - Use interactive educational websites (e.g., KidsPsych, PBS) that offer numerous imaginative games and provide interactive opportunities for children to support reading skills.

Teachers' Reported Use of Planned Learning Experiences

Section E of the questionnaire investigates teachers' reported use of pre-planned learning experiences for teaching reading skills and the extent to which these experiences reflect 21st -century

learning practices. The analysis is based on instructional strategies identified in the Alpha Teacher's Guide, which follows the CCSS framework and is recognized for its alignment with 21st-century learning needs (Jasperse et al., 2018c). This section summarizes selected planned learning experiences across nine reading skill areas identified in the CCSS curriculum.

A similar percentage of teachers using both the CCSS and CERD curricula report implementing planned learning experiences related to six key reading areas: Reading Strategies, Identifying Comprehension Skills, Identifying Story Elements, Phonological Awareness, Word Recognition, and Using Technology. The following examples illustrate additional practices and suggestions shared by teachers beyond the pre-planned activities.

In Reading Strategies, a CERD coordinator describes writing new words on the board, having students sound out each letter, read the words, and then learn their meanings - an approach that combines decoding with meaning-making. For Comprehension Skills, CCSS teachers emphasize using WH-questions to guide understanding while also supporting students' self-esteem during reading activities.

When addressing Story Elements, CCSS teachers highlight the value of connecting stories to students' lives to enhance memory and comprehension. They also note that identifying characters, feelings, or actions becomes easier once students understand key terms. For Word Recognition, a CCSS teacher illustrates that students count and read each word in a sentence and then memorize the new vocabulary words after fully understanding the paragraph, reinforcing both word recognition and comprehension.

In Using Technology, teachers from both curricula incorporate online resources—such as games and reading passages—to increase engagement. While the CCSS guide includes some suggested links, many teachers draw on additional online materials, and CERD teachers seek resources independently due to the lack of provided links.

In addition, a slight increase is observed in the percentage of CCSS teachers planning experiences that address Integrated Reading Skills through authentic learning, Context Clues, and Print Concepts compared to CERD teachers.

While both curricula teach vocabulary through context, 46.7% of CERD teachers still rely on memorization strategies compared to 16.7% of CCSS teachers. For print concepts, only 43.3% of CERD teachers report using hands-on punctuation activities. Nevertheless, experiences from both curricula generally support 21st -century skill development. One CCSS teacher highlights how pausing at punctuation marks helps build early fluency and comprehension.

Overall, teachers in both curriculum groups report instructional practices that support several 21st -century learning competencies, particularly digital engagement, communication, and comprehension. CERD teachers often supplement their limited official materials to meet these competencies.

Key Findings from the Teacher's Responses

Questionnaire responses indicate that teachers from both curriculum groups rely primarily on teacher guides when planning reading instruction. Teachers also use supplementary resources, including online materials, visual aids, and self-developed activities.

Teachers using the CCSS report more positive perceptions of curriculum organization, instructional support, reading objectives, and instructional materials than teachers using the Lebanese curriculum. The independent-samples t-test confirm statistically significant differences between the two groups, with CCSS teachers reporting higher ratings across curriculum implementation and reading instruction.

In contrast, teachers using the Lebanese curriculum report a stronger perceived need for curriculum improvement, including the addition of reading objectives, technology-based activities, real-life

connections, values-based content, and more comprehension-focused activities. They also report greater reliance on external resources to support reading instruction.

The analysis of planned learning experiences also shows that only five of the nine CCSS reading skill areas are consistently represented in the Lebanese curriculum's teacher guide, while integrated reading skills, print concepts, word recognition, and phonological awareness receive limited attention.

Teachers from both curriculum groups report using additional classroom activities to support reading development, including comprehension strategies, questioning techniques, technology-based resources, and cross-curricular learning experiences. These findings suggest that teachers adapt available materials and incorporate supplementary practices to support students' reading development.

Overall, teachers' responses indicate clear differences in perceptions of curriculum support and implementation. CCSS teachers report greater satisfaction with the available instructional guidance and resources, whereas teachers using the Lebanese curriculum highlight areas requiring further development and greater reliance on supplementary materials. These differences suggest that structured objectives, varied learning activities, and technology-supported resources may provide greater opportunities to promote literacy practices associated with 21st -century learning.

Discussion

Using the CIPP evaluation model (Stufflebeam, 2003), this study compares the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum with the CCSS across the context, input, process, and product dimensions of curriculum evaluation.

From the context perspective, the findings indicate that the Lebanese Grade 1 English curriculum demonstrates weaker alignment with contemporary literacy expectations and 21st -century learning competencies than the CCSS. This finding is consistent with those of Aljaafil and Beyhan (2021), who argue that the Lebanese curriculum has remained largely unchanged since 1997 and that long-standing educational inequalities have contributed to its weak alignment with 21st -century educational needs. The document analysis further shows less consistent progression of reading objectives, fewer authentic learning experiences, and more limited technology-supported literacy activities than the CCSS. These differences may limit opportunities for students to develop 21st -century competencies, particularly critical thinking, communication, and digital literacy.

From the input perspective, the document analysis identifies an uneven distribution of reading objectives, inconsistencies between curriculum objectives and workbook activities, limited activity types, and less comprehensive teacher guidance within the Lebanese curriculum. The CCSS Teacher's Guide provides detailed instructional strategies and activity suggestions for all targeted reading skills, whereas the CERD guide offers broader recommendations with fewer enrichment activities. Although neither curriculum explicitly includes technology-related reading objectives, the CCSS Teacher's Guide incorporates specific digital resources to support instruction, while the CERD guide provides only general recommendations regarding computer use.

The process evaluation highlights differences between the written curriculum and teachers' planned implementation. Only five of the nine reading skills emphasized within the CCSS—reading comprehension, story elements, context clues, fluency, and technology use—are consistently represented in the Lebanese curriculum's planned learning experiences. The analysis also reveals inconsistencies between curriculum objectives, workbook activities, and planned classroom instruction.

Teachers in both curriculum groups adapt available materials to meet classroom needs. However, this adaptation is more evident among teachers using the Lebanese curriculum, who rely more heavily on supplementary resources to compensate for perceived curriculum gaps. More than half of the

participants also report integrating reading instruction across other subject areas, supporting Dbaibo's (2016) view that cross-curricular learning contributes to reading development. These findings support Wiggins and McTighe's (2021) argument that meaningful learning depends on close alignment among curriculum objectives, instructional activities, and assessment.

From the product perspective, the more positive perceptions reported by CCSS teachers suggest that greater coherence among curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences may facilitate curriculum implementation.

Although this study does not directly measure students' reading achievement, the document analysis suggests that the stronger alignment among curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences within the CCSS may provide greater opportunities for students to develop foundational reading skills and 21st -century learning competencies. These interpretations are supported by teachers' perceptions of curriculum implementation collected through the questionnaire.

Conversely, the Lebanese curriculum places greater emphasis on context clues while giving comparatively less attention to phonological awareness, print concepts, and integrated reading experiences. This imbalance may reduce students' opportunities to acquire a balanced range of foundational reading skills unless teachers provide additional instructional support.

These findings suggest that curriculum reform in Lebanon should strengthen the coherence among curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences while ensuring a systematic progression of foundational reading skills. Greater emphasis should also be placed on authentic learning experiences, technology-supported literacy activities, explicit phonological awareness instruction, and comprehensive teacher guidance to strengthen early literacy development and 21st -century learning competencies.

The findings are consistent with previous research emphasizing curriculum alignment and systematic curriculum evaluation. Karimnia and Kay (2015) and Forouzandeh et al. (2008) argue that curriculum evaluation frameworks strengthen the relationship between curriculum design and implementation, while Wiggins and McTighe (2021) emphasize the importance of aligning learning objectives, instructional activities, and assessment. Consistent with Dbaibo (2016), the present findings suggest that stronger alignment between written curriculum objectives and classroom learning experiences, including cross-curricular learning opportunities, would enhance the quality of early reading instruction.

Overall, the document analysis and questionnaire findings demonstrate that the CCSS shows stronger alignment among curriculum objectives, instructional materials, planned learning experiences, and teachers' perceptions of curriculum implementation, while providing greater opportunities to support 21st -century learning competencies. In contrast, the Lebanese curriculum only partially aligns with these expectations and would benefit from greater coherence among curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences, together with stronger emphasis on authentic learning, explicit instruction in foundational reading skills, technology-supported literacy activities, and comprehensive teacher guidance.

Conclusion and Recommendations

This study finds that the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum demonstrates only partial alignment with the Common Core State Standards (CCSS) and lacks several foundational components needed for comprehensive early reading instruction. Although both curricula address reading comprehension, story elements, fluency, and context clues, the Lebanese curriculum provides limited attention to phonological awareness, print concepts, word recognition, authentic learning experiences, and other 21st -century learning competencies. This uneven emphasis may limit students' opportunities

to develop balanced foundational literacy skills, higher-order thinking, and the ability to apply reading in authentic and technology-supported contexts. Document analysis also reveal weak alignment between curriculum objectives and workbook activities, which may require teachers to supplement instruction with additional resources and self-developed learning experiences.

Questionnaire findings further indicate that teachers using the Lebanese curriculum rely more heavily on supplementary resources than teachers using the CCSS, who report stronger alignment between curriculum objectives, instructional materials, and planned learning experiences.

To strengthen the Lebanese Grade 1 English language curriculum, curriculum developers should establish a more systematic and coherent progression of reading skills and sub-skills, particularly in phonological awareness, fluency, print concepts, and story elements. Greater alignment between curriculum objectives, instructional materials, classroom activities, and assessment is also needed. In addition, expanding authentic learning experiences, integrating technology-supported literacy activities, providing more comprehensive Teacher Guides, and offering sustained professional development would strengthen curriculum implementation. While preserving the priorities of the Lebanese educational context, selected features of the CCSS may provide a useful reference for future curriculum reform.

This study is limited to the analysis of Grade 1 reading skills and teachers' questionnaire responses. Future studies could examine additional language skills and grade levels and incorporate classroom observations, teacher interviews, or student achievement data to provide a more comprehensive understanding of curriculum implementation and its impact on learning outcomes.

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Appendices

Appendix A:

Existing Lebanese grade 1 English language reading curriculum - Objectives and scope/sequence (CERD, n.d.):

General objectives - first cycle

- Comprehend and interpret basic factual information in short texts.
- Use phonological, morphological, and contextual clues to derive meaning.
- Develop reading strategies.

Grade one objectives

- Answer simple comprehension questions.
- Identify key facts in a text or events in a story.
- Group related lexical items.

Scope and sequence

- Develop comprehension of written discourse by:
  - Relating text to visual illustrations.
  - Identifying characters.
  - Suggesting story titles.
- Demonstrate awareness of written discourse by:
  - Matching words with corresponding illustrations.
  - Recognizing sentence boundaries.

Appendix B:

Common Core State Standards – Alpha publishing curriculum for Grade 1 English language objectives checklist: (eALPHA, 2018) (Jasperse et al., 2018c)

Strand	Topic	Main Objectives
Reading Literature	Key Ideas and Details	Ask and answer questions, retell stories, identify characters, settings, and major events.
	Craft and Structure	Identify words and phrases that convey meaning, distinguish literary and informational texts, identify the narrator.
	Integration of Knowledge and Ideas	Use illustrations to support understanding and compare characters' experiences.
	Range of Reading	Read grade-level literary texts with support.
Reading Informational	Key Ideas and Details	Ask and answer questions, identify the main topic and key details, describe relationships among ideas, events, or individuals.
	Craft and Structure	Determine word meanings, use text features, distinguish information from illustrations and text.
	Integration of Knowledge and Ideas	Use illustrations to explain ideas, identify supporting reasons, compare informational texts.
	Range of Reading	Read grade-level informational texts with support.
Reading Foundational	Print Concepts	Demonstrate understanding of print concepts and text organization.
	Phonological Awareness	Develop awareness of sounds, syllables, phonemes, blending, and segmenting.
	Phonics and Word Recognition	Apply phonics, decoding, syllabication, spelling patterns, and word recognition skills.
	Fluency	Read accurately, fluently, and with comprehension using appropriate rate, expression, and self-correction.

Appendix C: The Questionnaire

Instructions: This questionnaire is divided into five sections: A, B, C, D & E.

Section A. Demographic Background

1. Age
   - 21 – 30
   - 31 – 40
   - 41- 50
   - 51 or above
2. Gender
   - Male
   - Female
3. Highest Qualifications
   - PhD
   - Master's Degree
   - Bachelor's Degree
   - Other
4. Current Position
   - Coordinator of English Language Department / Cycle 1
   - Teacher of English Language / Grade 1
5. Teaching Experience in the current position
   - < 1 year – 5 years
   - 6 – 10 years
   - 11 –15 years
   - 16 years >
6. Type of institution you teach at
   - Public School
   - Private School
7. Name and address of the school
   ……
8. Name of the teacher (optional)
   ……
9. The curriculum used in teaching English Language for Grade 1
   - CERD Lebanese National Curriculum
   - CCSS (Common Core State Standards) Curriculum

Section B. Teachers' perspectives regarding the used curriculum

Instruction: Please rate how much you agree or disagree with each of the following statements by selecting the options.

Strongly disagree	Disagree	Slightly disagree	Slightly agree	Agree	Strongly agree
1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**

Statements	Strongly Disagree ⟷ Strongly Agree					
1. The curriculum is well-organized and developed	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
2. The content of the curriculum is convenient and coherent	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
3. The curriculum serves community needs and	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**

experiences continuous progress						
4. The curriculum supports students of different backgrounds and learning styles.	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
5. The curriculum includes reading techniques that are clear for teachers and students.	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
6. The curriculum uses suitable innovative tools	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
7. The curriculum has sufficient resources and visual aids	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
8. The curriculum prioritizes analytical skills over memorization	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
9. The designed teaching methods have a positive impact on the student's performance	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
10. Useful assessment methods are present in the curriculum	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**

Section C. Teachers' perspectives regarding reading skills

Statements	**Strongly Disagree ⟷ Strongly Agree**					
1. The objectives set for the reading skills meet Grade 1 student's needs and competencies	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
2. The reading objectives of kindergarten are compatible with Grade 1	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
3. The topics fit the class and the student's level	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
4. Reading texts are beneficial to students' culture	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
5. Reading texts are related to students' real-life	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
6. Reading texts are the right length for the class level	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
7. Textbooks include an acceptable number of questions related to reading skills	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
8. Teachers find no need to create new strategies in teaching reading skill	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**

9. What materials do you use to prepare the lesson plan concerning reading skills?
   - The Teacher Guide
   - Planned experience from other schools (activity booklets…)
   - Selecting ideas from the internet
   - Other……

Section D. Teachers' suggestions to develop the used curriculum in teaching reading skills

Statements	**Strongly Disagree ⟷ Strongly Agree**					
1. More reading objectives should be added	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
2. Develop objectives and activities that cater to today's needs (e.g. use of technology)	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
3. The curriculum needs to be aligned with the student's real life	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
4. A need to include topics that teach students discipline, values, and morals	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
5. A need for more activities that are related to the comprehension skill	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**

Other suggestions ……

Section E. Teachers' pre-planned learning experiences in teaching reading skills
How do the teachers design and introduce the following reading skills:

1. **Reading strategies and fluency**
   - Build background knowledge.
   - Preview the text using illustrations.
   - Model fluent reading and guide student reading.
   - Reread the text and discuss comprehension.
   - Other.
2. **Reading comprehension**
   - Encourage reading before answering questions.
   - Generate and discuss students' questions.
   - Answer comprehension questions individually or in pairs.
   - Other.
3. **Story elements**
   - Identify characters using text and illustrations.
   - Discuss characters, settings, actions, and feelings.
   - Encourage imagination and discussion.
   - Other.
4. **Integrated reading skills (text-to-text connections)**
   - Role play.
   - Integrate reading across subjects.
   - Make personal or text-to-text connections.
   - Use graphic organizers (e.g., Venn diagrams).
   - Other.
5. **Context clues / Vocabulary**
   - Write new words with their meaning on the board and ask students to memorize them (memorization strategies).
   - Practice vocabulary through discussion.
   - Illustrate new words.
   - Use pictures or flashcards to infer meaning.
   - Other.
6. **Print concepts**
   - Teach punctuation and sentence structure through guided activities.
   - Other.
7. **Phonological awareness**
   - Use rhyming and sound games.
   - Identify phonetic patterns in texts.
   - Practice sound recognition using word cards.
   - Other.
8. **Word recognition**
   - Practice word identification.
   - Build sentences using target words.
   - Sort words into categories.
   - Other.
9. **Use of technology**
   - Use interactive educational websites and digital reading activities.
   - Other.



Alaa M. Hjeij: Ms. Hjeij holds a Master's degree in English Language and Literature (Linguistics) and a Teaching Diploma. She has experience as a teacher, coordinator, and educational researcher, with expertise in curriculum development and interdisciplinary education. Her research interests include curriculum evaluation, early literacy, English language education, curriculum alignment, and 21st-century learning skills.